

ANI

Since its standoff with the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China in eastern Ladakh from May 2020, the army has deployed its entire range of artillery guns on the northern border, including the newly inducted K9 Vajra of Indian-South Korean make and the US-made M777 ultra-light howitzers. The M777s were procured through the foreign military sale route; the K9 Vajras were made in India by L&T. The induction of 100 pieces of the Vajra was done under a 2017 contract worth $720 million. The K9 Vajra-T is a variant of the South Korean K9 Thunder, considered by experts to be the world's best 155mm/ 52 calibre self-propelled howitzer in terms of the number of systems in active service. Though the K9 Vajras, delivered in 2018, were initially meant for deserts or plains, during the Ladakh standoff the army had to move these guns to forward locations on the icy heights. Artillery regiments had to procure anti-freeze winterisation kits to protect the guns' oil, lubricants and batteries at -30°C and even lower temperatures to ensure they function properly. However, the guns held up well. Now, the defence ministry has started the process for the procurement of 100 more K9 Vajras. An MOD official lets on that the ministry issued the Request For Proposal to L&T in November 2022. Once they respond to it, the contract negotiations will begin.

Immediately after the Kargil war, the Union government cleared the army's Field Artillery Rationalisation Programme, with a budget of Rs 50,000 crore. The target was to equip 169 artillery regiments with over 3,000 advanced-technology 155mm guns by 2020. But hiccups in the artillery procurement programme had given the Pakistan army an upper hand in the past few years. "With the induction of the M777 and K9 Vajra, we have managed to outclass Pakistan. Our main focus is now towards China, which has over 6,000 self-propelled artillery and towed artillery guns," says a defence official.

THE ARMY'S ARTILLERY INDUCTION PLAN AFTER KARGIL HAD FALTERED, GIVING PAKISTAN THE UPPER HAND. THE VAJRA AND M777 HAVE CHANGED THAT

In addition to the M777 and K9 Vajra, the Advanced Towed Artillery Gun System (ATAGS) developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and manufactured in collaboration with Bharat Forge Ltd and Tata Advanced Systems Ltd has reached a critical point—the gun has undergone extensive trials in all weather conditions. Similarly, the 130mm indigenous Sharang gun system has been remodelled for better range and accuracy. Then there is the indigenous 155mm towed howitzer, Dhanush, which too is now ready for field deployment.

Indian artillery is also being exported. Kalyani Strategic Systems, a subsidiary of Bharat Forge Limited, has announced that it has bagged an export order worth $155.5 million (about Rs 1,270 crore) for its 155mm, 39 calibre truck-mounted artillery guns.

Besides guns, Indian artillery regiments are also on course to induct the longer-range Pinaka multiple rocket launchers developed by the DRDO, as well as precision ammunition, loitering munition, unmanned aerial vehicles and reconnaissance and observation systems. "Operationalisation of the Pinaka multi-rocket launch system (MRLS) has added punch to the long-range capability of our artillery firepower, especially on the LAC. Guided Extended Range rockets with a range of 75 km have been developed and validated for the Pinaka," says an officer. He adds that currently, the army has five Grad rocket regiments, three Smerch regiments and four Pinaka regiments. An additional six Pinaka regiments are coming up. The Soviet-era Grad multiple rocket launchers are now made by the Directorate of Ordnance, while the Russian origin Smerch rocket launchers are mounted on Czech-designed Tatra trucks made in India by BEML. The army claims that over a period, the Pinaka will become the mainstay of the long-range rocket artillery.

With K9 Vajra, Dhanush, ATAGS, Sharang and Pinaka, India's artillery regiments are set for a transformation. It's a radical change, as these indigenous gun systems will not only end dependence on foreign players, but also bring the Indian military up to date on the latest artillery systems. ■